

“The challenge of being an entrepreneur is moving from a known territory and a steady life to one which is unpredictable.”

SAURABH SRIVASTAVA, 63
TRANSITION: From chairman of Xansa to founder of Infinity Ventures and co-founder of Indian Angel Network.

BIG IDEA: IAN brings multiple investors under one umbrella to invest in start-ups.
CHALLENGE: Finding good start-ups to invest in.



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Biosciences as promoter-chairman. A company set up in 2001 by G.V. Sanjay Reddy, it is an integrated research services provider. He was followed by BVR Subbu, former president of Hyundai Motors India, who set up Argentum Motors, an auto ancillary manufacturing firm with the promoters of Spicejet; IT veteran Saurabh Srivastava, who retired as Xansa chairman to set up Infinity Ventures, a venture capital firm, along with the Indian Angel Network, the country's largest business angel group with over 100 investors; and the likes of Electrolux MD Rajeev Karwal and Renuka Ramnath of ICICI Ventures, who, though not 'silver', have ventured into entrepreneurship. More recently, Narayana Murthy of Infosys, who is set to retire from the company's board in August next year, announced he had floated Catamaran, a venture capital fund for early and seed companies.

Srivastava jokes that the silver entrepreneurs, the equivalents of the baby boomers in the US, are increasingly getting less 'old' for their age and are looking for newer ways to channelise their energies. Increasingly, people are beginning to ask them-

selves: am I going to be in this job for the next 20 years or do I want to do something different?" Karwal, who started Milagrow Business and Knowledge Solutions which mentors micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs), says his motivation was to "be his own boss". Money, he says, is incidental. "It happens when you do business." However, Arun Maira, former chairman of the Boston Consulting Group, now a member of the Planning Commission, has a different take. He believes many of the shifts happened for want of choice. "At that age and that seniority then," he says, "few people would be looking for something very different to do."

Take Brar, for instance. After 27 years with Ranbaxy, he decided to set up his own venture. "I had envisioned starting a world-class company on my own," he says. His research, however, showed that the generic pharma space was already saturated and so a start-up had few chances of succeeding. Interested in R&D services, Brar chose biosciences.



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It was a growing industry with a lot of potential. The global outsourcing market for drug discovery is estimated to be \$60 billion of which discovery outsourcing is \$8 billion, and India and China are emerging as the favourites. Starting from scratch would have taken him three or four years to scale up, so he joined forces with Reddy. Today, the company has a turnover of Rs 250 crore, and is providing R&D services to 16 of the top 20 pharma companies around the globe for drug discovery in veterinary, agro and human pharma life sciences.

Similarly, Karwal, who has worked with a host of companies in the consumer goods sector, found a niche in mentoring and advising MSMEs which were either starting or scaling up, or even looking for a turnaround. There are about 350 million MSMEs in India which contribute about 45 per cent of the domestic manufacturing output and about 40 per cent of exports.

Whatever the motivation, these entrepreneurs are increasingly putting their industry experience, expertise, management skills and goodwill to good business use. For instance,